

AUSTRALASIA

AUSTRALASIA IS MADE UP of Australia and the islands of New Zealand and New Guinea, together with thousands of smaller Pacific islands. Australasia has been cut off from the rest of the world for millions of years, and many of the birds in the region are not found anywhere else. These include scrub-birds, lyrebirds, and the emu in Australia, bowerbirds in Australia and New Guinea, and the kiwis of New Zealand. Some birds that are common in other parts of the world are not found in Australasia, for example there are no pheasants or woodpeckers. A number of birds migrate to Australasia to escape bad weather at certain times of year—waders fly in from the north and seabirds from the south.

Since colonists arrived in Australasia about 200 years ago, many of the forests have been cleared, and the introduction of sheep, cattle, and rabbits to the ecosystem has destroyed many bird habitats.

Australia on the move

Over millions of years, continental drift has moved Australia slowly northward. About 100 million years ago, it was attached to Antarctica. But about 50 million years ago, it split off and started to drift. For about the next 30 million years, Australia was isolated from the rest of the world and many of its unique birds evolved. By about 10 million years ago, it had drifted near enough to Asia for some Southeast Asian birds to move into northern Australia.



Climate and landscape

The middle of Australia, called the outback, consists mainly of desert and has a hot, dry climate, although the southern coasts are cooler and wetter. A tropical climate, with warm, wet weather all year, occurs in northeast Australia and in New Guinea. New Zealand is cooler, with a temperate climate. The seasons in this southern part of the world are opposite to those in the north. For instance, when it is summer in Europe, it is winter in Australasia.

AMAZING BIRDS OF AUSTRALASIA

Speedy sleeper

The spine-tailed swift flies at speeds of up to 62 mph (100 kph) and can sleep while flying through the air.

Strong scent

The male musk duck has a strange pouch of skin under his bill which he uses to impress a female during his courtship display. The bird's name comes from the musky scent it produces during the breeding season.

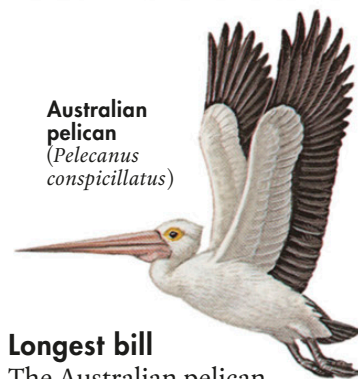


Musk duck
(*Biziura lobata*)

Curved bill

The wrybill of New Zealand is the only bird with a bill that curves to the right.

Australian pelican
(*Pelecanus conspicillatus*)



Longest bill

The Australian pelican has the longest bill in the world. It can be up to 1 ft 7 in (47 cm) long.

Biggest nest mound

The malleefowl builds a "compost heap" to keep its eggs warm until they hatch. The nest mound can be up to more than 16 ft (5 m) wide and 3 ft 3 in (1 m) deep.

Biggest birds

The emu and cassowary are the second and third largest birds in the world, after the ostrich. Like the ostrich, emus and cassowaries are too heavy to fly.

FACTS ABOUT AUSTRALASIA



Largest rock

Uluru (also called Ayers Rock), is the world's largest free-standing rock. It lies in central Australia and is 4 miles (6 km) long and 1½ miles (2.4 km) wide. It towers 1,143 ft (348 m) high above the desert floor.

Number of birds

More than 1,700 species of bird live in Australasia. About 45 percent of the birds that breed in Australia do not occur anywhere else in the world.

Longest river

The Murray-Darling is the largest river system in Australia—it is about 2,330 miles (3,750 km) long.

Largest coral reef

The Great Barrier Reef, off the northeast coast of Australia, is the largest living structure on Earth. It stretches down the coast for over 1,243 miles (2,000 km).

Highest geyser in the region

The Pohutu geyser, in the volcanic region of New Zealand's North Island, is a violent jet of steam and water that shoots out of the ground, reaching heights of 100 ft (30 m).



Least people

Fewer people live in Australasia than any other part of the world, except Antarctica. In Australia and New Zealand, sheep and cattle outnumber people by more than 10 to 1.

Flattest continent

Australia is the flattest continent. Almost two-thirds of its land surface is only 1,000–2,000 ft (300–600 m) above sea level.

Largest lake

The largest lake in the continent is Lake Eyre in Australia. The lake is often dry, but can cover an area of 3,436 sq miles (8,900 sq km) when flooded.